

# Gender, Sexuality, and Power: Critical Frameworks

## Course Level

Advanced Undergraduate / Grad  
Seminar

## Curriculum Format

10 Modules • 10 Reading Units • 10  
Applied Tasks

## Core Project Mandate

Critical Archive & Analytical Portfolio

## Theoretical Overview & Course Architecture

The investigation of human sexuality necessitates an engagement with epistemology, institutional governance, discursive power, and bodily autonomy. Historically treated either as an innate biological drive or a psychopathological impulse, contemporary critical theory repositions sexuality as a deeply mediated social construct. This seminar interrogates the discursive mechanisms through which erotic desires, classifications, and identity categories have been systematized from the late nineteenth century to our digital present.

Students will systematically trace how state governance, medicine, jurisprudence, and media intersect to enforce normative regimes of gender and intimacy while marginalizing non-conforming modes of existence. By parsing historical shifts—from colonial taxonomy to post-structuralist deconstruction—this project-oriented syllabus emphasizes not only theoretical deconstruction but also empirical archival documentation and public-facing analysis.

### Module 01: The Social Construction of Erotic Regimes

Foundations

Examining the shift from essentialist biological models to social constructionism. We scrutinize how scientific and legal authorities in Victorian modernity established normative scripts for male and female eroticism, rendering specific desires legible while relegating others to deviance.

**Assigned Reading 01:** Weeks, Jeffrey. *Sex, Politics and Society: The Regulation of Sexuality Since 1800* (Chapters 1–3: "The Social Meaning of Sex").

**Project Assignment 01:** Contextual Archive Dossier — Select one historical legal or medical document from 1850–1910 and author an 800-word analysis charting how it pathologizes non-reproductive intimacy.

### Module 02: Discursive Formations & The Repressive Hypothesis

Biopolitics

Unpacking Michel Foucault's critique of the repressive hypothesis. Rather than silence, modernity produced an unprecedented incitement to discourse concerning sex, creating categories of identity that became vehicles of administrative control and regulatory surveillance.

**Assigned Reading 02:** Foucault, Michel. *The History of Sexuality, Volume 1: An Introduction* (Part Two: "The Incitement to Discourse").

**Project Assignment 02:** Discursive Tracking Memo — Formulate a 1,000-word critical evaluation comparing contemporary social media moderation policies with Foucault's concept of institutional confessional practices.

## Performativity, Queerness, and Boundary Work

Moving beyond structural paradigms, contemporary scholarship highlights the iterative and theatrical qualities of bodily inscription. Gender and sexuality do not preexist the cultural acts that express them; rather, repeated stylizations of the body produce the illusion of an abiding internal essence. Resistance, therefore, emerges through conscious parodic subversion, spatial appropriation, and counter-hegemonic social organizing.

### Module 03: Performativity and Bodily Inscription

Gender Theory

A rigorous inquiry into Judith Butler's thesis of gender performativity. We analyze how normative heterosexuality relies on repetitive citations of bodily acts to maintain coherence, opening avenues for radical disruption through parodic reconfiguration.

**Assigned Reading 03:** Butler, Judith. *Gender Trouble: Feminism and the Subversion of Identity* (Chapter 1: "Subjects of Sex/Gender/Desire" & Chapter 3: "Subversive Bodily Acts").

**Project Assignment 03:** Performativity Field Observation — Observe and annotate a public cultural performance (digital livestream, public performance art, or drag event) in a 1,000-word critical field diary evaluating gestural citationality.

### Module 04: Spatial Geographies and Queering the Public Sphere

Spatial Politics

Space is not neutral; architecture, urban planning, and civic laws encode heteronormativity into public life. This module investigates queer worldmaking in spatial contexts, from cruising grounds and clandestine bathhouses to ballroom culture and commercialized enclaves.

**Assigned Reading 04:** Halberstam, Jack. *In a Queer Time and Place: Transgender Bodies, Subcultural Lives* (Chapters 1 & 2: "Queer Temporality and Postmodern Geographies").

**Project Assignment 04:** Cartographic Spatial Analysis — Construct an annotated spatial map detailing the transformation of an urban neighborhood, examining the tensions between commercial gentrification and subcultural refuge.

### Module 05: Intersectionality and Erotic Racialization

Intersectional Critique

Sexuality cannot be understood outside of racial hierarchy and imperial lineage. We analyze how Black feminist thought and women of color feminisms reframe the erotic as an epistemological site of knowledge, power, and resistance against colonial violence.

**Assigned Reading 05:** Lorde, Audre. *Sister Outsider: Essays and Speeches* ("Uses of the Erotic: The Erotic as Power" and "The Master's Tools Will Never Dismantle the Master's House").

**Project Assignment 05:** Textual Synthesis & Close Reading — Produce an 850-word synthesis evaluating Lorde's conceptualization of erotic wisdom versus commodified pornographic consumerism in modern popular music.

## Transnational, Colonial, and Relational Dimensions

The categories through which sexuality is regulated in the contemporary West are neither universal nor transhistorical. European colonial expansion actively dismantled indigenous gender structures, imposing rigid binary regimes to facilitate resource extraction and civic subjugation. Simultaneously, contemporary debates interrogate the family as an economic instrument of the state, questioning whether relational survival requires dismantling normative kinship.

### Module 06: Decolonial Queerness & Imperial Formations

Decolonial Thought

Investigating the historical imposition of European sexual binaries across colonized territories. This unit reviews how indigenous and non-Western expressions of sexual fluidity were violently erased or reclassified by colonial jurisprudence and missionary evangelism.

**Assigned Reading 06:** Lugones, María. *"Heterosexualism and the Colonial / Modern Gender System"* (Hypatia, Vol. 22, No. 1, pp. 186–209).

**Project Assignment 06:** Decolonial Jurisprudence Case Study — Review an anti-sodomy statute inherited by a post-colonial jurisdiction and formulate an 800-word legislative brief documenting its colonial provenance.

### Module 07: Non-Normative Kinship & Radical Care Networks

Kinship & Care

Challenging the nuclear family as the sole legally sanctioned provider of care, emotional stabilization, and asset inheritance. We scrutinize mutual aid societies, polyamory, chosen families, and communal networks forged during public health emergencies like the HIV/AIDS crisis.

**Assigned Reading 07:** Weston, Kath. *Families We Choose: Lesbians, Gays, Kinship* (Chapters 2 & 5: "Exiles from Kinship" and "Chosen Families").

**Project Assignment 07:** Oral History Interview Design — Draft a comprehensive 12-question qualitative interview protocol and consent statement targeted at documenting historical chosen-family mutual aid initiatives.

### Module 08: Technology, Intimacy, and Platform Algorithmic Governance

Digital Cultures

The mediation of intimacy via geo-locational dating applications, cam platforms, and social network algorithms. We examine the commercialization of sexual interaction, shadow-banning of queer content, and the monetization of dating behavioral data.

**Assigned Reading 08:** Noble, Safiya U. & Tynes, Brendesha M. *The Intersectional Internet: Race, Sex, Class, and Culture Online* (Selected Chapter: "Algorithmic Gatekeeping in Digital Intimacy").

**Project Assignment 08:** Digital Terms of Service Audit — Perform an audit of two modern dating platforms' privacy policies and moderation guidelines, producing a comparative technical matrix on content censorship.

## Biopolitical Governance, Neoliberalism, and Future Horizons

In late capitalism, sexuality has increasingly been assimilated into consumer market logics—a phenomenon critics term homonormativity or rainbow capitalism. As certain modes of respectability are embraced by state institutions through marriage and military inclusion, other forms of sexual and bodily autonomy remain precarious, criminalized, and heavily surveilled.

### Module 09: Homonormativity and Neoliberal Commodification

Political Economy

Analyzing the privatization of queer politics and the incorporation of sexual minorities into market-driven consumer cultures. We evaluate how the defense of domestic privacy replaces collective demands for universal healthcare, housing, and systemic liberation.

**Assigned Reading 09:** Duggan, Lisa. *The Twilight of Equality? Neoliberalism, Cultural Politics, and the Attack on Democracy* (Chapter 3: "The New Homonormativity: The Sexual Politics of Neoliberalism").

**Project Assignment 09:** Corporate Media Campaign Critique — Execute a multimodal semiotic deconstruction of a corporate pride marketing campaign, detailing the commodification of sexual liberation versus labor practices.

### Module 10: Abolition, Trans Care, and Radical Futures

Horizons

Synthesizing the semester's theoretical currents toward visionary horizons. We explore trans-affirming healthcare, prison abolition, decriminalization of sex work, and mutual aid structures designed to guarantee safety and flourishing outside state punitive regimes.

**Assigned Reading 10:** Spade, Dean. *Normal Life: Administrative Violence, Critical Trans Politics, and the Limits of Law* (Chapter 4: "Trans Law and Politics on a Neoliberal Landscape").

**Project Assignment 10:** Capstone Synthesis Essay & Defense — Submit a 2,500-word summative capstone essay integrating at least 4 assigned seminar readings to propose a concrete framework for transformative institutional care.

# Course Master Index: 10 Modules, Readings & Assignments

This master inventory provides an immediate reference for all semester milestones, corresponding reading assignments, theoretical topics, and project submission deadlines. All materials should be preserved in each student's ongoing research portfolio.

| Mod. | Thematic Focus                   | Core Reading & Chapter                                      | Deliverable Assignment                    |
|------|----------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|
| 01   | Erotic Regimes & Constructionism | J. Weeks, <i>Sex, Politics and Society</i> (Ch. 1–3)        | Historical Archival Dossier (800w)        |
| 02   | Discursive Formations & Power    | M. Foucault, <i>History of Sexuality Vol 1</i> (Pt. 2)      | Discursive Tracking Memo (1,000w)         |
| 03   | Performativity & Citationality   | J. Butler, <i>Gender Trouble</i> (Ch. 1 & 3)                | Performativity Field Observation (1,000w) |
| 04   | Spatial Politics & Geographies   | J. Halberstam, <i>In a Queer Time &amp; Place</i> (Ch. 1–2) | Urban Spatial Map & Commentary            |
| 05   | Intersectionality & The Erotic   | A. Lorde, <i>Sister Outsider</i> (Selected Essays)          | Textual Synthesis & Music Analysis (850w) |
| 06   | Decoloniality & Empire           | M. Lugones, <i>"Colonial Gender System"</i>                 | Decolonial Legal Brief (800w)             |
| 07   | Chosen Families & Care           | K. Weston, <i>Families We Choose</i> (Ch. 2 & 5)            | Oral History Interview Protocol           |
| 08   | Algorithmic Intimacy & Tech      | S. Noble & B. Tynes, <i>The Intersectional Internet</i>     | Platform Terms of Service Audit Matrix    |
| 09   | Homonormativity & Neoliberalism  | L. Duggan, <i>The Twilight of Equality?</i> (Ch. 3)         | Corporate Media Semiotics Critique        |
| 10   | Trans Politics & Abolition       | D. Spade, <i>Normal Life</i> (Ch. 4)                        | Capstone Research Paper (2,500w)          |

**Grading & Evaluation Criteria:**

- Weekly Briefs (Modules 1–5): **25%**
- Fieldwork & Audits (Modules 6–9): **35%**
- Final Capstone (Module 10): **40%**